

Divine Omnipresence

doc-divine-omnipresence

Theology Proper · Attributes · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.950
confidence high

Statement under examination

God is fully present everywhere, not bounded by space, while remaining distinct from creation.

In plain language

Three passages spread across the Bible make the same claim with different words. Psalm 139 verses 7 to 10 lists every spatial extreme a person could reach, up to the heavens (shamayim), down to the grave (sheol), east to the wings of dawn (shachar), west to the farthest sea (yam), and at each pole the answer is the same little word 'there' (sham), you are there, your hand leads me. The verb 'to flee' (barach) is used precisely because the questions assume no destination outside God exists. Jeremiah 23 verse 24 puts the claim in God's own voice with the verb 'to fill' (male), which takes both heaven and earth together under one object marker, the grammatical signature of unbounded presence, and adds that no one can 'hide' (sathar) in secret places. Acts 17 verses 27 and 28 carry the same idea into Greek, God is not 'far' (makran) from each one of us, and 'in' (en) him we 'live' (zao) and 'move' (kineo) and 'exist' (eimi), while the word 'Maker' (poiotes) in the same speech keeps the Creator and the creation apart, so being in him means located, not identical. The same heaven, grave, sea, and hide vocabulary returns in Amos 9, which is why the pattern is decisive rather than isolated. So the words clearly affirm both halves, present everywhere, yet distinct from what he fills and made. Where readers can still diverge is not over whether God is everywhere but over how to relate this to a second kind of language the same canon uses, a special covenantal presence that can be drawn near, dwelt in at the temple, departed from, as when Cain goes out from the 'presence' (panim) of the LORD and Jonah flees from the 'presence' (panim) of the LORD. The vocabulary marks both a presence of being that is everywhere and a presence of relationship that can be near or withdrawn, and it holds them together without ever ranking one above the other. That single unranked pairing is the only room the text leaves, and it does not touch the central affirmation.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0270	אָחַז	achaz	to grasp	64
H0319	אַחֲרִית	acharit	end	61
H0575	אֵן	an	where?	33
H0776	אֶרֶץ	erets	land	2,504
H1272	בָּרַח	barach	to flee	58
H3027	יָד	yad	hand	
H3220	יָם	yam	sea	
H3557	כּוּל	kul	to sustain	38
H3671	כַּנָּף	kanaph	wing	
H4390	מָלֵא	male	to fill	235

H5641	סתר	sathar	to hide	63
H6440	פנים	panim	face	2,126
H7138	קרוב	qarob	near	68
H7307	רוח	ruach	spirit	378
H7350	רחוק	rachok	distant	77
H7585	שואל	sheol	hell	54
H7837	שחר	shachar	dawn	
H8033	שם	sham	there	832
H8064	שמים	shamayim	heaven	378
G0575	ἀπό	apo	away from	
G0846	αὐτός	autos	it/s/he	
G1510	εἰμί	eimi	to be	2,457
G1722	ἐν	en	in/on/among	2,937
G2147	εὕρισκω	heurisko	to find/meet	181
G2198	ζάω	zao	to live	143
G2212	ζητέω	zēteō	to seek	
G2795	κινέω	kineo	to move	8
G3112	μακράν	makran	far	11
G4163	ποιητής	poietes	doer	6
G5225	ὑπάρχω	huparcho	be already	63
G5584	ψηλαφάω	pselaphao	to touch	4

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Three independent witnesses across poetry, prophecy, and narrative converge on one lexical pattern. Psalm 139:7-10 builds a double merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole), pairing heaven (shamayim, H8064) with the grave (sheol, H7585), and the wings of dawn (shachar, H7837) with the farthest sea (yam, H3220), exhausting the spatial extremes, and at each pole the locative 'there' (sham, H8033) asserts the same finding, you are there. Jeremiah 23:24 puts the claim in a first-person divine oracle with the verb 'fill' (male, H4390) governing both 'heaven' (shamayim, H8064) and 'earth' (erets, H0776) under one direct-object marker (eth, H0853), so that no person can 'hide' (sathar, H5641). Acts 17:27-28 carries the field into Greek with 'far' (makran, G3112), the participle 'existing' (huparcho, G5225), and the triad 'in' (en, G1722) him we 'live' (zao, G2198), 'move' (kineo, G2795), and 'are' (eimi, G1510), while 'Maker' (poietes, G4163) holds Creator and creation apart. The one boundary the words leave is that the same canon also speaks of a special covenantal presence, dwelling, drawing near, hiding the face, which the vocabulary holds together with the omnipresence of essence without ranking the two. No variant unit unsettles the verdict and the merism vocabulary recurs intact in Amos 9:2-3, so the pattern is pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) and decisive on the proposition's main claim.

Scripture

Ps.139.7 · **for** · genre: wisdom · figures: merism

Key terms. H0575 אן, H7307 רוח, H6440 פנים; H1272 ברח.

Force. Two parallel rhetorical questions, each opened by 'where' (an, H0575), ask where the speaker could go from God's 'Spirit' (ruach, H7307) and flee from his 'presence' or 'face' (panim, H6440). The queried tokens confirm the doubled 'where' (an) plus the verb 'flee' (barach, H1272). The grammar presupposes the answer no such destination exists, so the question itself encodes the omnipresence claim.

Ps.139.8 · **for** · genre: wisdom · figures: merism

Key terms. H8064 שמים, H7585 שאול, H8033 שם.

Force. A vertical merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) pairs 'heaven' (shamayim, H8064), the highest place, with 'the grave' or 'underworld' (sheol, H7585), the lowest. The locative 'there' (sham, H8033) plus the particle 'behold you' (hinnekka) asserts divine presence at each pole. The speaker's verbs are conditional (an 'if-then' clause structure), if I ascend, if I make my bed, but the presence asserted by 'there' (sham) is unconditional.

Ps.139.9 · **for** · genre: wisdom · figures: metaphor, merism

Key terms. H7837 שחר, H3671 כנף, H3220 ים.

Force. A horizontal merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) pairs the 'wings' (kanaph, H3671) of the 'dawn' (shachar, H7837) in the east with the farthest 'sea' (yam, H3220) in the west. The image presses the geographic limit case to test the claim of the previous verse.

Ps.139.10 · **for** · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H8033 שם, H3027 יד, H0270 אחז.

Force. Even at the prior verse's farthest point, the locative 'there' (sham, H8033) resumes and the divine 'hand' (yad, H3027) leads while the right hand 'grasps' or 'holds' (achaz, H0270) the speaker. The repetition of 'there' (sham) from verse 8 closes the frame of presence across every extreme just named.

Jer.23.23 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H7138 קרוב, H7350 רחוק.

Force. A first-person divine oracle, marked 'declaration of YHWH' (neum YHWH), poses a rhetorical question contrasting 'near' (qarob, H7138) with 'far' (rachoq, H7350). The ETCBC clause analysis (a Hebrew Bible syntax database) tags the unit a question with predicate-complement constituents, the structure of a self-disclosure that denies God can be a merely local, nearby deity unaware of the distant.

Jer.23.24 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H5641 סתר, H4390 מלא, H8064 שמים, H0776 ארץ.

Force. The queried tokens confirm the verb 'fill' (male, H4390) with first-person divine subject taking both 'heaven' (shamayim, H8064) and 'earth' (erets, H0776) under the direct-object marker (eth, H0853), denying that any person can 'hide' (sathar, H5641) in secret places. The interrogative particle (a question marker) on the verb makes the assertion emphatic, a denial framed as a question.

Acts.17.27 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2212 ζητέω, G5584 ψηλαφάω, G2147 εὐρίσκω, G3112 μακράν

Force. Paul states a purpose, that they might 'seek' (zeteo, G2212) God and perhaps 'grope after' (pselaphao, G5584) and 'find' (heurisko, G2147) him. The clause then adds, and indeed he is not 'far' (makran, G3112) from each one of us, with the participle 'existing' (huparcho, G5225). The queried Greek confirms 'far' (makran) plus 'existing' (huparcho) asserting nearness to every individual.

Acts.17.28 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1722 ἐν, G2198 ζάω, G2795 κινέω, G4163 ποιητής

Force. The triad 'in' (en, G1722) him we 'live' (zao, G2198), and 'move' (kineo, G2795), and 'are' (eimi, G1510), locates creaturely life, motion, and being inside God. The queried tokens confirm 'in' (en), 'live' (zao), 'move' (kineo), and 'are' (eimi) in the verse. The Creator-creature distinction is held by 'Maker' (poietes, G4163) language in the same speech, where God is the one who made the world, so the 'in' (en) is location not identity.

Amos.9.2 · **for** · genre: prophecy · figures: merism

Key terms. H7585 שאול, H8064 שמים, H8033 שם,

Force. A prophetic oracle reuses the same merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) vocabulary. The queried tokens show 'the grave' (sheol, H7585) and 'heaven' (shamayim, H8064) as the dig-down and climb-up extremes, with the locative 'there' (sham, H8033) asserting that even there the divine hand reaches. This is the Psalm 139 pattern recurring in a different genre, which corroborates the verdict pan-canonically (spread across the whole Bible).

Gen.4.16 · **complicates** · genre: narrative

Key terms. H6440 פנים,

Force. Cain goes out from the 'presence' or 'face' (panim, H6440) of YHWH and dwells in the land of Nod. The queried tokens confirm 'presence' (panim) here. The same word that Psalm 139:7 uses for the presence one cannot flee is used for a relational, cultic departure, which shows the vocabulary carries two senses, spatial omnipresence and covenantal nearness, that the canon does not collapse into each other.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Ps.139.7	Jer.23.23	tsk	1
Jer.23.23	1Kgs.20.23	tsk	1
Jer.23.24	1Kgs.8.27	tsk	1
Jer.23.24	Jer.49.10	tsk	1
Acts.17.27	Acts.14.17	tsk	1
Acts.17.27	Acts.15.17	tsk	1
Acts.17.28	1Sam.25.29	tsk	1
Acts.17.28	Luke.3.38	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Kgs.8.27 · **addressed**

Solomon asks whether God can dwell on earth when the heavens and the highest heaven cannot 'contain' (kul, H3557) him. The queried tokens confirm 'contain' (kul) governing 'heaven' (shamayim, H8064) alongside 'earth' (erets, H0776) and the house being built. The container language denies any spatial bounding of God while affirming a real, non-exclusive temple presence, so it reinforces rather than contradicts the verdict.

Gen.4.16 · **addressed**

Cain departs from the 'presence' or 'face' (panim, H6440) of YHWH. The queried tokens confirm 'presence' (panim) here. The idiom names covenantal favor and cultic locale, not ontological absence (absence of being). The same 'presence' (panim) that one cannot flee in Psalm 139:7 is the 'presence' (panim) one can leave relationally here, so the word carries a special-presence sense alongside the omnipresence-of-essence sense without ranking them.

Jonah.1.3 · addressed

Jonah flees from the 'presence' or 'face' (panim, H6440) of YHWH toward Tarshish, and the queried tokens confirm 'presence' (panim) twice plus a flight verb, the very pair from Psalm 139:7. The narrative then has YHWH hurl a wind on the sea in the next verse, so the attempted flight is shown futile by the storyline itself, confirming omnipresence by counter-example.

Amos.9.3 · addressed

The oracle says that even if they 'hide' (sathar, H5641) on the top of Carmel or at the bottom of the 'sea' (yam, H3220), God will search and seize them. The queried tokens confirm 'hide' (sathar) and 'sea' (yam) here. The verse is a complicating-looking flight scenario that the text itself resolves against the fugitive, so it supports the verdict rather than unsettling it.

Concordance traversed

H8064, H0776, H4390, H7350, H7138, H5641, H1272, H7585, H8033, H7307, H6440, H0575, H0319, H0270, H3557, G3112, G5584, G2198, G2795, G5225, G2147, G4163, G1722, G1510, G0575, G0846

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Acts 17:27-28 sits outside the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window (3 John 1:1 to 1:15), so no CBGM apparatus (the genealogical method for tracing manuscript readings) was examined. Known minor witnesses vary on the article with 'God' (theos) and on the optative form (a Greek mood expressing wish or possibility), but none touches the 'far' (makran), 'in' (en), or 'existing' (huparcho) vocabulary that carries the verdict. Psalm 139 and Jeremiah 23 are Old Testament and outside ECM scope. The verdict holds across all plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked

omnipresence_of_essence: affirms · Reads 'fill' (male, H4390) and the merism (the extremes-naming figure) plus the 'in him we live' (en, G1722) language as predicating unbounded spatial presence of the divine being itself. On this reading God is wholly present at every point, and the near and far oracle of Jeremiah 23:23-24 forecloses any local-deity limitation. The vocabulary directly supports this as the proposition's main claim.

special_covenantal_presence: affirms_with_distinction · Stresses that the same canon uses a distinct register for a localized, manifest presence, dwelling in the temple in 1 Kings 8, drawing near, going out from the 'presence' or 'face' (panim, H6440) in Genesis 4:16 and Jonah 1:3, hiding the face. On this reading the words affirm omnipresence of essence but leave the manner of God's special presence as a further category the lexicon marks but does not rank against the first. This lens is represented in its strongest form, it does not deny omnipresence, it adds that presence is spoken of in more than one mode.

panentheism: partial_affirm · Reads Acts 17:28, 'in' (en, G1722) him we live and move and are, as locating creation within God, which the preposition 'in' (en) allows. But the same speech keeps 'Maker' (poiotes, G4163) and the world-making language, so the lexical context blocks an ontological identification (an identification at the level of being) of God with creation. The reading is fairly stated, it captures a real feature of the 'in' (en) clause, but the surrounding vocabulary limits how far it can be pressed.

pantheism: denies · Would erase the Creator-creature line that Jeremiah 23, God 'fills' (male, H4390) versus persons 'hide' (sathar, H5641), and Acts 17, 'Maker' (poiotes, G4163) versus made, both keep. The lexical pattern preserves the distinction the proposition requires, so a strict identification of God with the world is not supported by the words.

The verdict rests on grammatico-historical reading (interpreting the text by its grammar and original historical setting) of three independent texts plus the corroborating Amos 9 echo. The two-part proposition, present everywhere yet distinct from creation, is held by reading the spatial 'fill' (male, H4390) and merism (the

extremes-naming figure) language together with the explicit 'Maker' (poietes, G4163) vocabulary in each context. The honest residue is that the canon also speaks of a special covenantal presence, which the lenses above register without the words ranking essence-presence above manifest-presence.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition restates the lexical pattern, fully present everywhere, not bounded by space, while remaining distinct from creation, without importing a tradition-specific taxonomy (a labeling system tied to one school of thought). The 'fill' (male, H4390) and merism (the extremes-naming figure) vocabulary and the 'Maker' (poietes, G4163) language match both halves of the statement, so the verdict is derived from the text and not smuggled by the stem.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.139.7-10
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Jer.23.23-24
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Amos.9.2-3
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Kgs.8.27
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Jer.23.23
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Jer.23.24
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H4390
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3557
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6440
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3112
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5225
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.17.27-28
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Ps.139.7
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Jer.23.24
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